Typography itself is speaking

Abstract: The Art of Design | Jonathan Hoefler: Typeface Design

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Typography / Architecture / Type/ Readability / Communication

On the recommendation of Prof. Grady, this was my first time watching Abstract, a Netflix-produced series of art documentaries about culture, creativity, and the fashion and creative industries. The overall tone and production strongly attracted me, and the series includes many design masters and their design journeys.

I first chose the episode Jonathan Hoefler: Typeface Design, which interested me the most. On one hand, I am a big fan of the Hoefler Text typeface in Apple’s system, and Jonathan Hoefler is its designer. On the other hand, I have recently been working on the type design for the main visual of this year’s SVA MFA exhibition, and I am also working on typography-related tools at spark!, so I was very curious about what a master designer’s process looks like. The typefaces he designed are loved by many people and are often used in everyday visual systems.

In the video, Jonathan Hoefler was commissioned by Abbott Miller to design a typeface for the Guggenheim Museum rebranding, which became a challenge of combining architecture and typography. His goal was to move the typeface from a decorative signage style to a more conservative system for text and headlines, so that the museum name and the type on the windows would create the same feeling. For him, if different uses of the typeface communicate the same feeling, the system is successful. This made me realize that typography is not about individual letterforms, but about system consistency, and whether the whole system can truly communicate the original intended feeling.

The documentary also mentions the Gotham typeface and discusses the role of typography in public communication through the visual system of the Obama campaign. The design team did not see type only as something “beautiful” or “readable.” They saw it as a language system with expressive power. When people see a letterform or a word, they do not only receive the literal information of the text itself. Typography

itself is speaking. It is a medium with expressive power. It influences how people understand information, how they build cognitive connections, and how things develop. It changes the way people communicate and interact. Type does not only serve content. It participates in building the meaning structure of the content itself.

At the same time, this made me feel a strong contradiction. What designers do is often very subtle, hidden, and difficult to notice directly. But these small design choices are truly embedded in the world's communication systems. They become part of the structure of everyday communication and long-term shape how people understand the world. Many typeface "characters" are not innate. They are formed later through being used, being recognized, and being defined by their contexts of application.

Yes is More

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Architecture / Space / Interaction / Complexity / Constraints / Inclusion / Yes is More / Sustainability / Infrastructure / Social Impact / Innovation

One thing that really draws me to architecture is how architects look for solutions within so many limitations and layers of complexity. Architecture is always about how space interacts with people and how people move, meet, and live inside it. Architects always find different ways to respond to these questions, and that is what excites me the most. Because of this interest, I also like to think about spatial interaction in graphic design, even though it is a flat medium.

Starting from this interest, I chose this episode of Bjarke Ingels. Bjarke Ingels is from Copenhagen, Denmark. He is the Founder and Creative Director of BIG, Bjarke Ingels Group. In the video, he says, “In the big picture, architecture is the art and science of creating the framework of our lives. The buildings we create can either open up possibilities,

or they can limit encounters and connections between people."
The video introduces many of Bjarke's projects in Copenhagen. "If everybody followed the rules, Copenhagen wouldn't look like Copenhagen." Through his work, I can clearly see a unique quality that comes from him being a Copenhagen local. He always wants to do something different. One of my favorite works shown in the video is called Copenhill. It is a waste to energy power plant with a large public park on the roof where people can ski. It is the tallest building in Copenhagen, and at the same time, it represents a strong environmental idea. As Bjarke says, "If you have a power plant that is so clean you literally have clean mountain air, instead of having to be far away from it, you can enjoy it." When I heard this, I was honestly amazed. I thought this idea was incredibly smart and constructive. The chimney, instead of being a symbol of pollution, becomes a celebration. He turns infrastructure into something that has a real positive social and environmental impact.
This way of thinking connects closely to Bjarke Ingels' slogan, "Yes

is More.” He talks about an inclusive approach to architecture, where everyone’s input is taken seriously and pushed to the extreme. Every concern matters, no matter how small. They do not stop until every issue has been considered and incorporated into the design. This attitude of accepting complexity instead of avoiding it is what impressed me the most.

Similar to Egyptian hieroglyphics and Mayan writing in Central America, the Chinese writing system is a purely visual language. It is not alphabetical, and every symbol is composed of a number of differently shaped lines within an imaginary square. Legend holds that Chinese was first written about 1800 BCE by Cangjie, who was inspired to invent writing by contemplating the claw marks of birds and footprints of animals. Cangjie proceeded to develop elementary pictographs of things in nature. These images are highly stylized and composed of a minimum number of lines, but they are easily deciphered. The Chinese sacrificed the realism found in hieroglyphs for more abstract designs.

Aesthetic considerations seem to have interested the Chinese from

the early beginnings of their writing. Simple nouns were developed first, and the written language slowly matured and became enriched as characters were invented to express feelings, actions, colors, sizes, and types. Chinese characters are logograms, graphic signs that represent an entire word. (The sign $, for instance, is a logogram representing the word dollar). Ideographs and phonetic loans—borrowing the sign of a similar-sounding word—were developed, but written Chinese was never broken down into syllable signs, like cuneiform, or alphabetic signs for elementary sounds. Therefore, there is no direct relationship between the spoken and written Chinese languages. Both are independent systems for conveying thought: a sound from the mouth to the ear, and a sign from the hand to the eye. Learning the total vocabulary of forty-four thousand characters was the sign of wisdom and scholarship. The Japanese adapted the Chinese logograms for their written language despite the great differences between the two spoken languages. Similarly, different spoken Chinese dialects are

written with the same logograms.

The earliest known Chinese writing is called chiaku-wen, or “bone-and-shell” script (Figs. 3-1 and 3-2), used from 1800 to 1200 BCE. It was closely bound to the art of divination, an effort to foretell future events through communication with the gods or long-dead ancestors. This ancient writing—as with hieroglyphics and cuneiform—was pictographic. Chinese pictographs are found incised on tortoise shells and large animals’ flat shoulder bones, called oracle bones, which convey communications between the living and the dead. When one wished to consult an exalted ancestor or a god, one asked the royal diviner to inscribe the message on a polished animal bone. The diviner pushed a red-hot metal bar into a hole in the inscribed bone, and the heat produced an intricate web of cracks. The diviner then read or interpreted these cracks, which were believed to be messages from the dead.

The next phase of Chinese calligraphy, called chin-wen, or “bronze” script, consisted of inscriptions on cast-bronze objects, including food

and water vessels, musical instruments, weapons, mirrors, coins, and seals. Messages were inscribed in the casting molds to preserve answers received from gods and ancestors during divination. The permanence of bronze also made it suitable for important treaties, penal codes, and legal contracts. Ceremonial vessels used to hold food offerings during ancestor worship and vessels inscribed with dedications (Fig. 3-3) contained well-formed characters in orderly alignment. Most inscriptions were made inside the vessels, and the characters were more studied and regular than in the bone-and-shell inscriptions.

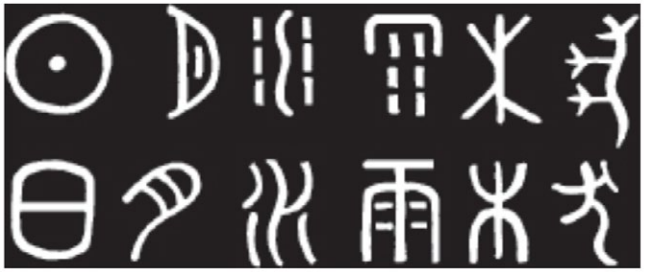

Fig. 3-1

Fig. 3-2

Fig. 3-3

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